participants. One analysis estimated that out of a sample of 20 million tweets generated during the 2016 US election campaign, 3.8 million (almost 20 per cent) were generated by bots.[48]

By the early 2020s, things got worse. A 2020 study assessed that bots were producing 43.2 per cent of tweets.[49] A more comprehensive 2022 study by the digital intelligence agency Similarweb found that 5 per cent of Twitter users were probably bots, but they generated 'between 20.8% and 29.2% of the content posted to Twitter'.[50] When humans try to debate a crucial question like whom to elect as US president, what happens if many of the voices they hear are produced by computers?

Another worrying trend concerns content. Bots were initially deployed to influence public opinion by the sheer volume of messages they disseminated. They retweeted or recommended certain human-produced content, but they couldn't create new ideas themselves, nor could they forge intimate bonds with humans. However, the new breed of generative AIs like ChatGPT can do exactly that. In a 2023 study published in *Science Advances*, researchers asked humans and ChatGPT to create both accurate and deliberately misleading short texts on issues such as vaccines, 5G technology, climate change and evolution. The texts were then presented to seven hundred humans, who were asked to evaluate their reliability. The humans were good at recognising the falsity of human-produced disinformation but tended to regard AI-produced disinformation as accurate.[51]

So, what happens to democratic debates when millions – and eventually billions – of highly intelligent bots are not only composing extremely compelling political manifestos and creating deepfake images and videos but also able to win our trust and friendship? If I engage online in a political debate with an AI, it is a waste of time for me to try to change the AI's opinions; being a nonconscious entity, it doesn't really care about politics, and it cannot vote in the elections. But the more I talk with the AI, the better it gets to know me, so it can gain my trust, hone its arguments and gradually change my views. In the battle for hearts and minds, intimacy is an extremely powerful weapon. Previously, political parties could command our attention, but they had difficulty mass-producing intimacy. Radio sets could broadcast a leader's speech to millions, but they could not befriend the listeners. Now a political party, or even a foreign government, could